



Product Design & UX Principles

Week 2 • Day 3 • Strategic Design & Metrics

TPM Academy



Day 3 Objectives

- Use **Nielsen's 10 heuristics** as a shared vocabulary with designers
- Add three **TPM-specific lenses**: time-to-first-value, failure-mode dignity, power-user respect
- Run an **A11y floor audit** in 20 minutes — the non-negotiable accessibility checks for any TPM
- Audit a real product surface and rank findings by severity
- Convert audit findings into **3 design principles** a squad can hold the line on



Today's Shape

Clock	Block	Outcome
09:00 – 09:15	Opening	What product surface is your triad auditing?
09:15 – 10:30	Block 1 + Activity 1	Heuristic Hunt
10:45 – 12:00	Block 2 + Activity 2	A11y Floor Audit
13:00 – 14:15	Block 3 + Activity 3	Heuristic Audit (your surface)
14:30 – 16:00	Block 4 + Activity 4 + Readouts	3 Design Principles

Block 1 — The Shared Vocabulary

Nielsen's 10, plus three TPM lenses

Why TPMs Need This Vocabulary

Designers and engineers will both override your reaction with their craft language. The TPM job is to **name what's wrong in the language they will accept**, then defend why it matters with metrics.

Without vocabulary

"This screen feels weird. Can we redo it?"

Loses the conversation in 30 seconds.

With vocabulary

"This screen violates Nielsen #5 (error prevention) and #6 (recognition over recall). The cost shows up in our reconcile-abandonment signal."

Wins the conversation.



Nielsen's 10 Heuristics

#	Heuristic	One-line
1	Visibility of system status	The user always knows what just happened and what's happening now
2	Match real world	Use the user's words, not the system's
3	User control & freedom	Undo, exit, escape — always
4	Consistency & standards	Same word, same color, same place
5	Error prevention	Make destructive actions hard, not easy
6	Recognition over recall	Show options, don't make me remember them
7	Flexibility & efficiency	Beginners get hand-holding, experts get shortcuts
8	Aesthetic & minimalist	Every screen element earns its place
9	Recover from errors	The error message names the field and the fix
10	Help & documentation	Findable, in-context, searchable



Three TPM-Specific Lenses

11. Time-to-first-value

Can a new user produce a useful result in their first session? Measured in minutes, not features.

12. Failure-mode dignity

How does the product behave when the network drops, the data is wrong, or the user is rushed? Failure is part of UX.

13. Power-user respect

Does the product reward repeat use with shortcuts, or punish it with the same friction every time?

Why these three: they're the heuristics designers most often skip in early-stage products and most often blame on engineering later.

Activity 1 — Heuristic Hunt

Triads • 35 minutes

Walk through a B2B SaaS none of your triad uses (provided link). Each member silently captures 3 heuristic violations.

- Pool and de-dupe
- Identify the **most painful** + **most subtle** violation
- Prepare a 60-second readout naming the heuristic numbers



5 min solo • 15 min pool • 10 min cull • 5 min readout prep

Block 2 — The A11y Floor

The 8 checks every TPM should run before any PRD ships



Why a Floor, Not a Ceiling

Accessibility is a **regulatory floor** (ADA, Section 508, EAA), an **SEO floor**, and a **usability ceiling**. Fixes for keyboard-only users almost always fix mouse-user errors too.

The TPM responsibility: not to be the a11y expert, but to refuse to ship a feature that fails the floor — and to spot failures unsolicited.



The 8-Check Floor

Check	Tool	Fail looks like
Keyboard-focusable interactives	Tab through the page	Focus disappears
Visible focus indicator	Tab through the page	No outline on focus
Color contrast 4.5:1 (text) / 3:1 (large text)	WebAIM contrast checker	Light gray on white
Form fields have labels	Screen reader / inspect	"Edit text, blank"
Images have alt text	View source	Empty alt on meaningful image
Logical heading hierarchy	Outline tool	Jumps h1 → h4
Errors identify the field	Submit broken form	"Error" with no field
Touch targets $\geq 44\text{px}$	Mobile devtools	Buttons too small

Activity 2 — A11y Floor Audit

Triads • 40 minutes

Run the 8-check floor on the FieldPulse mobile or your chosen surface. Split the checks across triad members so all 8 are covered (plus one overlap).

- Each fail: which UX heuristic is also being violated?
- Output: one-page **A11y Floor Audit** for the surface



25 min audit • 10 min cross-link to heuristics • 5 min summarize

Block 3 — Audit Your Surface

Apply the calibrated eye + the floor to the triad's chosen flow



The Audit Template

- **Top 3 violations** with heuristic + observation + cost + severity (1–5)
- **Top 3 strengths** — what does this product do better than the average B2B SaaS?
- **A11y Floor Audit result** (Pass / Partial / Fail)
- **TPM Lens findings**: time-to-first-value, failure-mode dignity, power-user respect
- **One question** you cannot answer without the design team

Strengths matter: a "kill list" of violations alienates designers. Naming what works builds trust to address what doesn't.



Severity Scoring (1–5)

Score	Meaning	Example
5	User task failure or data loss	"Submit" button unlabeled — user can't complete reconcile
4	Recurring frustration; users work around	Date picker requires 5 taps — users keep paper logs
3	Slows users; stopwatch would notice	Tab order skips "amount" — users mouse over
2	Cosmetic; affects trust	Inconsistent button styling
1	Edge case	Tooltip cut off in landscape

Activity 3 — Heuristic Audit of Your Surface

Triads • 40 minutes

Use the audit template on your triad's chosen flow. Severity-score each violation. Capture strengths.

- 10 min: solo walk-through (each member captures 3+ findings)
- 15 min: pool + score severity
- 10 min: write up the template (top 3 violations + strengths)
- 5 min: name the one question only design can answer



10 solo • 15 pool • 10 write • 5 question

Block 4 — From Audit to Principles

The keeper artifact: 3 design principles your squad can hold the line on

What a Design Principle Looks Like

A design principle is a **statement**, not a feature. It is **decision-making** — when two options compete, the principle picks one.

✓ Good

Why

"If a dispatcher can't recover from a mis-tap in 1 second, we built it wrong."

Specific, decision-making, memorable

"Show network state on every screen — assume connectivity is broken."

Names a constraint, drives concrete choices

"Power users get keyboard shortcuts. New users get them visible too."

Resolves a tension explicitly

✗ Bad

Why

"Be user-friendly"

Vacuous

"Use Material Design"

A toolkit, not a principle

"Be consistent"

True but not actionable



Cull to Three

1. **Cluster audit findings into themes.** Each theme suggests a principle.
2. **Draft 5 candidate principles.** Some will be bad. That's fine.
3. **Test each:** when two options compete, does this tell us what to choose?
4. **Cull to 3.** Three is the limit for memorability.
5. **Write each principle** as one line + one example of a decision it would force.

Activity 4 — Three Design Principles

Triads • 45 minutes • Readouts

Convert your audit into 3 design principles your squad can hold the line on.
Each principle: one line + one decision it would force.

- 10 min: cluster findings into themes
- 15 min: draft 5 candidates
- 10 min: test & cull to 3
- 10 min: write the principle card



10 cluster · 15 draft · 10 cull · 10 write · 90s readouts



Day 3 Wrap

What we built

- Shared vocabulary (Nielsen + 3 TPM lenses)
- The 8-check A11y floor
- A severity-scored UX audit
- 3 design principles per triad

What opens tomorrow

- **Using AI for strategy & research summaries**
- Reuse the Week-1 prompt patterns at strategy scale
- Process the FieldPulse interview + ticket pack

Bring to Day 4: Your triad's NS Defense Card, Tier Sheet, and 3 design principles — they all become inputs to AI summarization tomorrow.

Questions & Reflection

Which of your 3 principles will the design team disagree with most?